

An Autistic Teenager in Your Coaching / Activity

For sports coaches, PE teachers & activity leaders — supporting an autistic teenager (roughly ages 12–18).

The one idea

Autism, through **monotropism**, means a teen's attention locks into a few deep, intense "tunnels." Sport can be a lifeline at this age — a place of routine, mastery, friendship and recovery from the social drain of school — *if* the environment fits. This is the **peak age for anxiety, depression and burnout**, and many autistic teens mask heavily all day and arrive at training already depleted. Predictability, sensory kindness, clear roles and a coach who "gets it" can make your club the safest hour of their week.

What you may see — and what's really going on

You may see...	What's often happening
Exhausted, "can't be bothered," skips sessions	Probable burnout or depletion — not lack of commitment
Meltdown or shutdown at the whistle or after a loss	Involuntary response to overload; shame makes it worse
Intense focus on technique, stats or one event	Monotropic strength — a route to mastery and identity
Won't join the team huddle or social after	High social load, not rudeness — give a defined role instead
Takes feedback literally; needs a moment to answer	Literal, single-channel communication + processing time

Try this

- **Predictable structure and routine**; warn before any change to drills, teams or fixtures.
- **Show, then say; one instruction at a time**; use video/whiteboard for tactics.
- **Manage sensory load** — quieter spaces, ear-defenders, warning before whistles/buzzers; offer individual options.
- **Give a clear role** and use the interest (the stat-lover keeps the book; the routine-lover leads the warm-up).
- **Focus on mastery and relationship** — a teen who trusts you will push through more; celebrate effort, not just results.
- **Have an overload plan** — an agreed quiet space and a signal to step out, no questions asked.

Avoid this

- Surprise changes, public criticism, or "tough love" that shames a shutdown.
- Forcing eye contact, team socials, or huddles with no opt-out.
- Equating a masked session or a withdrawal with "not trying."

When to get more support

Watch for **autistic burnout** — exhaustion, loss of skills, reduced tolerance — and take it seriously; rest and reduced load are recovery, not weakness. Liaise with parents if you see crisis signs, and keep your club a low-demand, accepting space. High-quality friendship through sport is powerfully protective.

If the teen is a girl or marginalised gender

Camouflaging peaks here; a “quiet, capable, sociable-on-the-surface” teen may be running on empty. Watch for private collapse and check in literally and privately.

About this guide

*AI-assisted, derived from this project's research drafts — **Growing Up Monotropic** (Part 4, sports & coaching), the **Lifespan Practitioner & Health-Care guide** (Part 3.3) and the **Monotropism** brief. Uses identity-first language. **Informational — not a diagnostic tool**. Fit it to the individual.*

Key sources. Murray, Lesser & Lawson (2005); Murray, F. (2023); Michaud & Harvey (2025, physical-activity scoping review); Dwyer (2025); Raymaker et al. (2020, burnout). Full citations are in the source drafts.